

SIX-WEEK CHALLENGE

2018

INTRO: We are embarking on a season of new beginnings. It is a new year and we are all trying to get started off on the right foot. Many are no doubt making New Years resolutions.

As we begin this year, I want to offer a challenge to us as a corporate body of believers. I am challenging you to do the following things for the next six weeks: (January 14 – February 18)

- Fast... Fast one meal a day for six consecutive weeks - or one day a week for six consecutive weeks.
- Read the Word each day for six consecutive weeks... Read at least 3 chapters a day for six consecutive weeks – Join me for my daily Facebook devotional at 7:15 AM Monday through Friday for six consecutive weeks.

- Tithe 10 % of our total family income for six consecutive weeks... Faithfully tithe on your gross family income for six consecutive weeks.
- Attend church and a life group for six consecutive weeks... Attend the 10 AM Sunday morning service and a life group for six consecutive weeks.
- Serve in a ministry or outreach for six consecutive weeks... Do something to serve your church for six consecutive weeks.
- Reach out to un-churched people for six consecutive weeks... Make a hit list of six un-churched families and invite one of them each week to church and life group with you over a six consecutive week period.

CHALLENGE # 1 – FAST A MEAL A DAY FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS OR FAST A DAY A WEEK FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS...

I am challenging you today to begin a six-week journey with me. I am asking you to do the following from today through February 18, 2018:

- Fast one meal a day every day for six consecutive weeks...
- Or, fast one day a week for six consecutive weeks...

I want to take a few moments and establish a Scriptural basis for why we should practice the discipline of fasting. Fasting is a Scriptural principle. One hundred sixty times the Bible references the word fasting or some variation of it.

The word fast means *one who has ~~not~~ eaten, one who is empty*. I call fasting dying. Our word “*breakfast*” simply means to break our time of fasting between the evening ~~and~~ morning meal. Sad to say, but that is about as much fasting as most Christians ever do. (I almost fasted last week... I almost prayed today...)

Fasting in the Old Testament:

- Pastor Moses fasted... (Fasted 40 days twice – The result; the Ten Commandments)
- The Children of Israel fasted... Judges 20, 1 Samuel 7, 1 Samuel 31, 2 Samuel 1
- King David fasted... 2 Samuel 12, Psalms 69, Psalms 109
- King Ahab fasted... 1 Kings 12
- The servants of Saul fasted... 1 Chronicles 10
- The prophet Ezra fasted... Ezra 8&9
- Nehemiah fasted... Nehemiah 1 (He fasted until God sent him to Jerusalem to rebuild the broken city)
- Mordecai fasted... Esther 4 (Fasted for an intercessor)
- Zechariah and the priests fasted... Zechariah 7
- The prophet Daniel fasted... (Fasted 21 days before receiving an answer and visions) Daniel 9&10
- The prophet Joel fasted... Joel 2

History tells us; during the time between the Old Testament and the New Testament fasting became a Jewish characteristic.

Fasting in the New Testament:

- The Pharisees fasted...
- Jesus fasted... Matthew 4, Mark 2, Mark 9
(This time of fasting prepared Him for public ministry)
- Anna fasted... Luke 2
- Cornelius fasted... Acts 10 (The Lord sent Peter to present the gift of the Holy Spirit to the gentile world)
- The Apostles fasted... Acts 13 (Paul and Barnabas were selected as the first missionaries of the New Testament church)
- Paul fasted... 2 Corinthians 6, 2 Corinthians

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Fasting is both an Old Testament and New Testament principle and activity. If fasting is a New Testament principle it is certainly worthy of the consideration of every Christian.

Ok, so we have established that fasting is an Old Testament and a New Testament principle but why should we fast?

Let me begin this segment of this study by saying that fasting will not persuade God to do anything that He would not ordinarily do. If you are fasting to convince God to do a miracle you are wasting your time. God already desires to give good things to His children. Matthew 7:11 (KJV) ***“If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”*** 2 Chronicles 16:9 (NKJV) ***“For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him...”***

If fasting does not convince God to do anything He would not ordinarily do; why fast?

- The words of Jesus implore us to do so...
Matthew 9:14-15 (NLT) ***“One day the disciples of John the Baptist came to Jesus and asked him, “Why do we and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples don’t fast?” 15 Jesus responded, “Should the wedding guests mourn while celebrating with the groom? Someday he will be taken from them, and then they will fast.”***
- Fasting is the duty of every Christian. Matthew 6:16 (NLT) ***“And when you fast, don’t make it obvious, as the hypocrites do, who try to look pale and disheveled so people will admire them for their fasting. I assure you, that is the only reward they will ever get.”***
- Fasting crucifies the flesh... The flesh is the enemy of faith and therefore it is the enemy of God.
Galatians 5:16-26 (NLT) ***“So I advise you to live according to your new life in the Holy Spirit. Then you won’t be doing what your sinful nature craves.***

17 The old sinful nature loves to do evil, which is just opposite from what the Holy Spirit wants. And the Spirit gives us desires that are opposite from what the sinful nature desires. These two forces are constantly fighting each other, and your choices are never free from this conflict. 18 But when you are directed by the Holy Spirit, you are no longer subject to the law. 19 When you follow the desires of your sinful nature, your lives will produce these evil results: sexual immorality, impure thoughts, eagerness for lustful pleasure, 20 idolatry, participation in demonic activities, hostility, quarreling, jealousy, outbursts of anger, selfish ambition, divisions, the feeling that everyone is wrong except those in your own little group, 21 envy, drunkenness, wild parties, and other kinds of sin. Let me tell you again, as I have before, that anyone living that sort of life will not

inherit the Kingdom of God. 22 But when the Holy Spirit controls our lives, he will produce this kind of fruit in us: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, and self-control. Here there is no conflict with the law. 24 Those who belong to Christ Jesus have nailed the passions and desires of their sinful nature to his cross and crucified them there. 25 If we are living now by the Holy Spirit, let us follow the Holy Spirit's leading in every part of our lives. 26 Let us not become conceited, or irritate one another, or be jealous of one another.” Fasting kills all of the above – Fasting crucifies the old man – If you get crucified you are dead - And dead men do not lust!

- Fasting humbles the believer before God... Fast a few days and you will find yourself more humble than ever before.

- Fasting teaches the believer dependence upon God as his source...
- Fasting expresses submission to God... Submission to God helps us appreciate the need of self-discipline (Matthew 6:10 NKJV) “*Your kingdom come. Your will be done On earth as it is in heaven.*”
- Fasting prepares us to receive revelation from God... (Moses, David, Nehemiah and Daniel)
- Fasting brings victory... To be Christlike is a victory. Doubt is of the flesh, refusal to crucify the flesh brings defeat. When we crucify the flesh we have victory.
- Fasting places the believer in a position of hearing from God... (Daniel – 21 days)

CONCLUSION:

Challenge # 1 – Fast a meal a day from now through February 1st or fast a day a week from now until February 1st (Or – Choose a time when you can do one of these for six consecutive weeks)

Fasting is water only – No food whatsoever – Who will join me in this discipline for the next six weeks?

CHALLENGE # 2 - READ THE WORD DAILY FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS...

Joshua 1:8 (NKJV) "*This Book of the Law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate in it day and night, that you may observe to do according to all that is written in it. For then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have good success.*"

Psalms 119:96-106 (NKJV) "*I have seen the consummation of all perfection, But Your commandment is exceedingly broad. 97 Oh, how I love Your law! It is my meditation all the day. 98 You, through Your commandments, make me wiser than my enemies; For they are ever with me. 99 I have more understanding than all my teachers, For Your testimonies are my*

*meditation. 100 I understand more than the
ancients, Because I keep Your precepts.
101 I have restrained my feet from every
evil way, That I may keep Your word. 102 I
have not departed from Your judgments,
For You Yourself have taught me. 103
How sweet are Your words to my taste,
Sweeter than honey to my mouth! 104
Through Your precepts I get
understanding; Therefore I hate every false
way. 105 Your word is a lamp to my feet
And a light to my path. 106 I have sworn
and confirmed That I will keep Your
righteous judgments.”*

Speaking to Judas, not Iscariot, Jesus said,
John 14:23-24 (NKJV) “*If anyone loves
Me, he will keep My word; and My Father
will love him, and We will come to him and
make Our home with him.*” 24 “*He who does
not love Me does not keep My words; and
the word which you hear is not Mine but
the Father’s who sent Me.*”

The Bible:

- Contains 66 books... Divided into the Old and New Testaments - 39 in the Old and 27 in the New.
- The Bible was written by more than 40 authors over a time span of 1500 years...
- The Bible was written by shepherds, farmers, tent-makers, physicians, fishermen, priests, philosophers and kings; yet it does not contradict itself even once...
- The Bible has been translated into more than 2,000 languages, with countless more partial translations, and audio translations... In comparison, Shakespeare, considered by many to be the master writer of the English language, has only been translated into 50 languages.
- The Bible is still the best seller of all time...

The Bible is often referred to as the Word of God. The reason we refer to this book in this way is because that's exactly what it is - The Word of God. If it is the Word of God we should read it every day. The Bible can be defined in the following way:

- B - Basic
- I – Instruction
- B – Before
- L – Leaving
- E- Earth

In our daily Bible reading we will receive answers for yesterday's questions. We will also find solutions for tomorrow's dilemma, which we have not yet anticipated. How is this possible? Hebrews 4:12 (NKJV) ***"For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart."***

Though there are hundreds of reasons to consistently read the Word of God, I want to look at just a few of them:

- We should read the Bible because it is divinely inspired and infallible... I want to be very clear on my stand with regard to these issues, I believe the Bible to be both divinely inspired and completely infallible. If we cannot believe in the inspiration and infallibility of Scripture, how can we believe anything the Bible says? In my mind, we must believe all of it, or none of it!
- We should read the Bible to receive knowledge... The Bible is the owner's manual for human beings. It is the google for Godly instructions. The Holy Spirit, who is our teacher, brings the Word to life as we read it.
- We should read the Bible to receive hope... One of the most significant problems in our world today is

hopelessness. What is the answer for our society? The Word of God! It is amazing what a little hope will do! Hope can, cause a plan for an abortion to result in the birth of a baby... Convert suicidal thoughts into a plan for the future... Turn a criminal into a law-abiding citizen... Transform a divorce proceeding into a loving marriage... Change a financial flop into an overwhelming success... Modify stress from a health problem into a testimony...

CONCLUSION:

Reading the Bible furnishes the believer with a daily dose of hope! When you visit a doctor for the purpose of acquiring antibiotics to fight an infection he will often give what is referred to a “bolus dose” of medication. This is a greater amount than the normal daily dose. The “bolus dose” is

designed to give your body a jumpstart of antibiotics in an effort to fight the infection.

When the daily doses of hope that we receive from reading the Bible begin to accumulate, the believer no longer walks in doubt concerning the future, but moves energetically and enthusiastically toward it.

The difficulties of life do not tend to sidetrack the believer who receives an adequate amount of hope through daily Bible reading.

I am asking you to commit to two things:

- Read three chapters of your Bible per day for six consecutive weeks...
- Watch my 7:15 AM daily Facebook devotional each day (Monday – Friday) for six consecutive weeks...

CHALLENGE # 3 - TITHE 10% OF YOUR TOTAL FAMILY INCOME FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS...

Malachi 3:8-12 (NKJV) *"Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed Me! But you say, 'In what way have we robbed You?' In tithes and offerings. 9 You are cursed with a curse, For you have robbed Me, Even this whole nation. 10 Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it. 11 "And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, So that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground, Nor shall the vine fail to bear fruit for you in the field," Says the LORD of hosts; 12 "And all nations will call you blessed, For you will be a delightful land," Says the LORD of hosts."*

Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) "A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed." 34 These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai."

Luke 6:38 (NLT) "If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over.

Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you.”

2 Corinthians 9:6-7 (NKJV) "But this I say: He who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. 7 So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver."

Tithing is a subject that most ministers shy away from, simply because they know that the giving nerve is, with most people, a very sensitive nerve. Teaching on the principles of giving is one of the responsibilities of pastoral ministry.

The Bible has much to say about giving; therefore a pastor is indebted to his parishioners to teach good, sound, Biblical, principles for giving. Just because there are

people in the church who are uncomfortable with the pastor talking openly about money does not release him from the responsibility of teaching on the subject!

You can tell where a person's heart is by taking a quick look at their checkbook! Jesus reiterated this in Matthew 6:21 (NKJV) ***“For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”***

Someone asked Willie Sutton, the notorious bank robber, why he robbed so many banks. He replied, *"That's where the money is."* Each of us will leave a clear money trail to the location of our most valuable treasure!

Whether you like it or not, whether you are comfortable or uncomfortable with your pastor talking about money, the fact is that money is something we all deal with every day and we desperately need to use proven

Biblical principles to guide our business practices!

Those of us who are operating in a true spirit of stewardship will continually ask ourselves the following question. *"What would God have us to do with what He has entrusted to us?"* If this question rules our life then we get it! We have a real shot at becoming the stewards God would have us to be! Once we become the stewards God would have us to be, the tithing debate will be settled in our life. We will tithe because we realize everything we have belongs to the Lord, the tithe never belonged to us to begin with therefore we cannot GIVE IT, all we can do is RETURN IT!

The Lord has required of us as His business managers to invest a minimum of ten percent back into His Kingdom!

Here are several Biblical reasons for us to tithe 10% of our total family income:

- We should tithe 10% of our total family income because we do not want to become a thief... And least of all steal from God! Malachi 3:8 (NKJV) ***"Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed Me! But you say, 'In what way have we robbed You?' In tithes and offerings."*** (\$20 bill illustration)
- We should tithe 10% of our total family income because we have been commanded to do so... Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) ***"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected***

on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed.” 34 These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai.”

Malachi 3:10 (KJV) **“Bring all the tithes into the storehouse...”** It would be literally impossible for a rational person to read these two Scriptures and conclude tithing is anything other than a commandment! Tithing is not a suggestion for a Christian; it is a commandment to honor God with our finances. This commandment is not because He needs our money; it is because we need to give!

- We should tithe 10% of our total family income because we want to walk in obedience... The government of God

and man is predicated upon the principle of each person adhering to the laws set forth by God and man. If the law is not followed, judgment must be enacted upon the offender. If judgment is not enacted upon the offender eventually anarchy will set in and everyone will be a law unto themselves, and will do that which is right in their own eyes!

Everyone in this place is aware that for a society to function properly there must be laws and penalties for breaking those laws. When we obey the laws we live under the blessing, protection and favor of the government. Tithing is the law of God – If we are obedient to his laws we get the blessings He has promised!

Obedience is rewarded BIGLY! We are told in Scripture that the ***“Obedient soul shall be made fat”*** and that, ***“The disobedient shall be cast into hell.”***

- We should tithe 10% of our total family income because we want to avoid being

cursed... Malachi 3:9 (NKJV) ***"You are cursed with a curse, For you have robbed Me, Even this whole nation."***

Being blessed is living under the divine providence and protection of God. Being cursed is having that protection and provision removed and being made vulnerable to the attacks of the enemy. (The show alone) The first thing they do is build a shelter to get them out of the elements and to protect them from the wild animals. Tithing is the shelter of protection from the elements and the enemies.

- We should tithe 10% of our total family income because we want to be blessed... Malachi 3:10 (KJV) ***"Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room***

enough to receive it.” The word blessing comes from the Hebrew word baraka (bear-aw-kah), and means: Source of blessing - prosperity - praise of God - a gift or present - a treaty of peace. Who would not want to enact this in their lives? I will tell you who – the people who do not tithe 10% of their total family income to the Lord. When we get blessed by the Lord the end result should be ***“There is not room enough to receive it.”***

- We should tithe 10% of our total family income because we want the devourer to be rebuked... Malachi 3:10-12 (NKJV)
“Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this,” Says the LORD of hosts, “If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it. 11 “And I will rebuke the

devourer for your sakes, So that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground, Nor shall the vine fail to bear fruit for you in the field,” Says the LORD of hosts; 12 “And all nations will call you blessed, For you will be a delightful land,” Says the LORD of hosts.” (Talk about what God spoke to me about this) Even though we pay our tithe or plant the seed through obedience, the enemy of the harvest is never far away. Any good farmer knows that his work is not complete with the sowing of the seed; he must till the ground and tend the crop because the harvest has many enemies! (Drought, wind, hail, temperature and insects) In this Scripture the enemy of the harvest is identified as "***The devourer.***" Who is the devourer and how should we deal with him? The devourer is readily revealed in Scripture. John 10:10 (NKJV) "***The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to***

destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.” If we tithe 10% of our total family income we release the Lord to ***“Rebuke the devourer for our sakes.”*** Webster says to rebuke is to criticize sharply; to reprimand; to turn back or keep down! You may say, *“Sign me up for the Lord to rebuke the devourer for my sake!”* You have to sign yourself through obedience! Tithing IS the sign up!

CONCLUSION:

Notice what happens when we tithe 10% of our total family income and the devourer is rebuked by the Lord:

- He will not destroy the fruit of your ground...
- The vine will not fail to bear fruit for us...
- All nations will call us blessed... (The Jones nation – The Smith nation – The

Garza nation – The Ramirez nation –
The Wong Fu nation!

- You will be a delightful land...

We should return tithe 10% of our total family income for the insurance benefit it offers; God will rebuke the devourer for our sakes!

I challenge you to tithe 10% of your total family income for six consecutive weeks!

CHALLENGE # 4 – ATTEND CHURCH AND A LIFE GROUP FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS...

(My history) In forty-nine years of living on this earth there has never been a time when I was not *"In Church"*:

- I was raised in a church!
- I was dedicated to the Lord in a church!
- I was saved in a church!
- I was baptized in water in a church!

- I was received into membership in a church!
- Susan and I were married in a church!
- We dedicated our children in a church!
- We have raised our family in a church!
- My funeral will be held in a church!

I am literally a product of the church.
 Because I am a product of the church, I am a champion of the church. I would fight hell with a water pistol in defense of the church!

I know there are some stinkers (Hypocrites) in the church but Noah had a couple of stinkers (Skunks) on his boat as well, but it was the best thing afloat! Stay in the boat!

- Jesus went to church and met in homes... Luke 4:16 (NKJV) ***"So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, ..."***

- The apostles went to church and attended life groups... Acts 3:1 (NKJV) ***"Now Peter and John went up together to the temple at the hour of prayer, ..."***
"They broke bread from house to house..."
- We are commanded to go to church and to have fellowship with one another... Hebrews 10:25 (NKJV) ***"Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching."***

The example of church attendance by Jesus and His disciples, as well as the scriptural commandment for us to attend church more regularly as we see the end time approaching is surely based on more than an effort to give us something to do to occupy our time! There are many reasons for a mandate concerning church attendance; I want us to focus on a few of them.

When I talk about church attendance I am talking about not only attending the 10 AM Sunday service but also attending a life group.

- We should attend church and a life group to be fed spiritually... If we are faithful to our church and life group the pastor and life group leader will not only preach to us, but teach us line upon line, precept upon precept, all the while building us up in our most Holy faith. The first step to living a successful Christian life is to attend church and a life group faithfully. For at least six consecutive weeks!
- We should attend church and a life group to function as a body... As individual believers, we are not the body of Christ; we are a part (One part) of the body of Christ. When we connect ourselves as we should to a local church, it helps us realize we are a part of

something bigger than we are individually. Being connected to a local church aids us in our attempt to understand what it means to be a part of the corporate or triumphant church.

Matthew 16:18 ***“And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.”***

Being connected to the local church points up the fact, we should make a contribution to other believers, by offering up our abilities in service to them. When we are a faithful part of the local church we become aware of the importance of every other member of the local church. 1 Corinthians 12:18-20, 27 (NKJV) ***“But now God has set the members, each one of them, in the body just as He pleased.19 And if they were all one member, where would the body be?20 But now indeed there are many members, yet one body. - 27 Now you***

are the body of Christ, and members individually." Every member of the body is vitally important but we must be TOGETHER to function with maximum impact.

- We should attend church and a life group for the opportunity to exercise our gifts... Every believer has natural gifts and abilities that they were born with. The reason we were born with these abilities is because they will fold perfectly into the spiritual gifts God will give us as we attempt to fulfill the purpose of God for our lives. The best place on the planet for developing our gifts is the local church. The development of our gifts is the process of walking out our destiny. We are following HIM one step at a time as HE develops us; moves us closer to our destiny; and then takes us to the next level of development, which was no doubt His original intention. 2 Peter

3:18 (NKJV) "*Grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ...*" Where can this best happen? At church or in a life group!

CONCLUSION:

My challenge to you is to attend church and a life group for at least six consecutive weeks.

God ordained the church for the purpose of ministering to the saints and reaching the world. We cannot very well reach the world if we are not receiving ministry from others and offering ministry to others.

What better place to receive and give ministry than the local church?

Take a moment to think about what kind of Christians we would be if the following were not available to us:

- No other Christians to fellowship with...

- No teachers to teach us...
- No discipleship to train us...
- No Pastor to shepherd us; counsel us; marry us; or bury us...
- No small groups that allow us to do life together...

I want to close with this question: *“What kind of church would this church be, if every member were just like me?”*

Can we commit ourselves today to making this a much better church by attending church and a life group for six consecutive weeks? The first step of living a successful Christian life is to connect oneself to a church and to attend faithfully.

CHALLENGE # 5 – SERVE IN A MINISTRY FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS...

Romans 12:1 (NKJV) *"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God,*

***that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service.*"**

Matthew 23:10-12 (KJV) "Neither be ye called masters: for one is your Master, even Christ. 11 But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. 12 And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted."

Our society is geared toward leadership rather than serving. Everywhere you turn you see a new best-selling book or a conference being advertised, all having to do with leadership. John Maxwell said *"Everything rises and falls on leadership."* I am certainly not in a position to dispute Mr. Maxwell but I believe the bedrock of our effectiveness is tied to what Jesus said in Matthew 23:10-12 (KJV) ***"Neither be ye called masters: for one is your Master, even***

Christ. 11 But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. 12 And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted."

Someone said "*He who bows lowest, stands the tallest.*" Jesus not only preached and taught servant-hood but He modeled it as well. Everywhere Jesus went He found a way to serve the people:

- He preached in their Synagogues...
- He taught them valuable life lessons...
- He healed the sick...

Most of us have become saturated with lessons on how to be a good leader, what we need is to figure out how to incorporate a little servant-hood into our leadership. Servant leadership is the most effective kind of leadership.

I want us to look at some Biblical reasons for serving:

- Serving is worship... (Explain how mature Christians worship – They worship not to music but with a towel on their arm serving others) Jesus said to Peter... John 21:15 (NKJV) *"So when they had eaten breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me more than these?" He said to Him, "Yes, Lord; You know that I love You." He said to him, "Feed My lambs."* The writer of Romans calls our service to God's people *"Our reasonable service."*
- We are to serve in an effort to demonstrate God's love for others... The Bible makes very clear the love of God for all the people of this world. John 3:16 (KJV) *"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting*

life." There is no greater way to manifest the love of our Heavenly Father than to love someone who does not deserve it! Matthew 5:46 (NKJV) ***"For if you love those who love you, what reward have you?"*** I am challenging each of us to find a place to serve others for six consecutive weeks for the purpose of demonstrating His love for others! (I pray every day that as I reach out and touch the people of this church that when I pull my hands back, you will have the fingerprints of God on your life because He has touched you through me!)

- We are to serve others as a demonstration of our faithfulness to God... None of us would question God's faithfulness to us. The \$64,000.00 question is our faithfulness to Him. God is faithful even when we are not, but life is made richer and fuller when we reciprocate His faithfulness. When we

serve others our service is a demonstration of our faithfulness to Him. Jesus placed a premium on faithfulness and servant-hood. There is a reward to be gained from serving faithfully. There is a consequence for lack of serving. Unfaithful people lose out because of neglect. Hebrews 2:3 (NKJV) ***"How shall we escape if we neglect so great a salvation?"*** We must re-prioritize our entire life if necessary. Faithful service is essential both now and in eternity. Speaking of the parable of the talents, Jesus says the following of the faithful servants. Matthew 25:21 (NKJV) ***"His lord said to him, 'Well done, good and faithful servant; you were faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things. Enter into the joy of your lord.'***

I am challenging each one of us to serve for six consecutive weeks for the purpose of demonstrating my faithfulness to Him!

CONCLUSION:

Serving God and serving His Church introduces great satisfaction in the life of His servants! I want to conclude today by asking a few soul-searching questions:

- Who is called to serve? Everyone!
- Why do we need to serve? To demonstrate our love for God and others!
- Where do we need to serve? Find a ministry – Volunteer in an outreach!
- Who did Jesus say would be greatest in the Kingdom of God? Whoever is servant to all!

I challenge you to serve in a ministry for six consecutive weeks!

CHALLENGE # 6 – REACH OUT TO UN-CHURCHED PEOPLE FOR SIX CONSECUTIVE WEEKS...

John 3:16-17 (NKJV) *"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.17 "For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved."*

1 Corinthians 1:18 (NKJV) *"For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."*

My challenge to us is that we make ourselves a hit list of families we know who are un-churched and invite one of those families to church and a life group each week for six consecutive weeks.

Thom Rainer said: *"Eight out of ten un-churched men and women said they would go to church if only someone would invite them."*

I want us to look at some reasons we should accept the challenge we are being offered today:

- We should accept this challenge because we have been commanded to do so...
Mark 16:15 (NKJV) ***"And He said to them, "Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature."*** Please understand this is not *"The great suggestion"*; this is *"The great commission!"* I am afraid we have taken a view of this Scripture that does not do justice to the intent behind the words of our Lord. Parting instructions are the most important instructions. Jesus summed it all up by telling the disciples to ***"Go preach the Gospel to every***

creature.” (Tomb of the Unknown Soldier – Orders remain unchanged)

- We should accept the challenge because people are perishing... There is a very dangerous doctrine making the religious circles and it is known as *"Eventual Reconciliation."* *"Eventual Reconciliation"* is quite possibly one of the most dangerous heretical doctrines to make religious circles in the history of the church. This doctrine says as long as a person does not know the way, God will eventually reconcile them whether or not they have received Christ! Let me emphasize to you a major truth of the Gospel, all who have not received Christ are eternally lost! Psalm 9:17 (NKJV) ***"The wicked shall be turned into hell, And all the nations that forget God."*** Revelation 20:15 (NKJV) ***"And anyone not found written in the Book of Life was cast into the lake of fire."*** We must accept this challenge because all who

have not heard and have not received are perishing!

- We should accept this challenge because the harvest is calling us... In the Scripture, when you read of the harvest the Bible is speaking of something more precious than a little grain in the field, it is speaking of eternal souls who are coming to a place of being lost. One thing I learned while pastoring in a farming community is that NOTHING is more important than the harvest! It is a matter of survival! Listen to what Jesus has to say about the harvest! John 4:35 (NKJV) ***“Do you not say, ‘There are still four months and then comes the harvest’? Behold, I say to you, lift up your eyes and look at the fields, for they are already white for harvest!”*** When wheat is white in the field, this means it is on the verge of being overripe and any little movement in the stalk, or radical weather change could cause the crop to

be lost! Time is of the essence; reapers are needed; the crop must be harvested! Jesus made a prayer request with regard to this. Matthew 9:37-38 (NKJV)

"Then He said to His disciples, "The harvest truly is plentiful, but the laborers are few.38 "Therefore pray the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into His harvest." We should accept this challenge because the harvest is calling us! We should also accept this challenge to answer the prayer request of Jesus – ***"Pray that the Lord of the harvest will send laborers..."*** I want to challenge some parents in here today who have unchurched children and grandchildren to have a family meeting and ASK your family to come to church and a life group with you! (Break your silence – Use your influence – Get over your timidity)

- We should accept this challenge because hell is requesting it... We hear so little

about hell that people by and large have determined there is no such place. (My experience with Linda Crawford's mother in Fouke Arkansas) Hell is a real place! Jesus paints a word picture with regard to this awful place. Luke 16:19-26 (NKJV) *"There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day: 20 And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was laid at his gate, full of sores, 21 And desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table: moreover the dogs came and licked his sores. 22 And it came to pass, that the beggar died, and was carried by the angels into Abraham's bosom: the rich man also died, and was buried; 23 And in hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments, and seeth Abraham afar off, and Lazarus in his bosom. 24 And he cried and said, Father Abraham, have mercy on me,*

and send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue; for I am tormented in this flame. 25 But Abraham said, Son, remember that thou in thy lifetime receivedst thy good things, and likewise Lazarus evil things: but now he is comforted, and thou art tormented. 26 And beside all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed: so that they which would pass from hence to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that would come from thence." Notice several things about this Scripture:

1. This is a story about a rich man and a poor man... (The spiritual connotation is the saved and lost)
2. Both men died... (Vs. 22) *"And it came to pass, that the beggar died - The rich man also died..."* Hebrews 9:27 (NKJV) *"And as it is appointed for men to die once, but after this the judgment."*

3. One went to eternal peace; the other went to eternal punishment... (Vs. 22)
“The beggar died, and was carried by the angels into Abraham’s bosom...”
(Vs 22 & 23) ***“...The rich man also died, and was buried; 23 And in hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments.”***
(All will be divided into only two groups, the lost and the saved)
4. One rejoiced; one begged... (Vs. 23) ***“In hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments, - Seeth Abraham afar off, and Lazarus in his bosom.”*** (Speaking of role reversals)
5. The rich man followed his life pattern, thinking first of self (Vs. 24)
“Send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue...”
6. The rich man experienced the torment of the flames of hell... (Vs. 24)
“I am tormented in this flame.” (Mark 9:43-48 NKJV) ***“If your hand causes***

you to sin, cut it off. It is better for you to enter into life maimed, rather than having two hands, to go to hell, into the fire that shall never be quenched—44 “where 1 ‘Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.’ 45 “And if your foot causes you to sin, cut it off. It is better for you to enter life lame, rather than having two feet, to be cast into hell, into the fire that shall never be quenched—46 “where ‘Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.’ 47 “And if your eye causes you to sin, pluck it out. It is better for you to enter the kingdom of God with one eye, rather than having two eyes, to be cast into hell fire—48 “where ‘Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.’”

7. The rich man experienced eternal separation from God... (Vs. 26) *“And beside all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed: so that they*

which would pass from hence to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that would come from thence.” (Eternal separation from God will be the worst thing about hell!)

The story does not end there! Luke 16:27-31 (NKJV) *“Then he said, ‘I beg you therefore, father, that you would send him to my father’s house,²⁸ ‘for I have five brothers, that he may testify to them, lest they also come to this place of torment.’²⁹ “Abraham said to him, ‘They have Moses and the prophets; let them hear them.’³⁰ “And he said, ‘No, father Abraham; but if one goes to them from the dead, they will repent.’³¹ “But he said to him, ‘If they do not hear Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded though one rise from the dead.’ ”*

The church struggles with evangelism but hell is full of passionate evangelists! THINK

OF THIS – All six un-churched families you have placed on your hit list are going to spend eternity in heaven or hell! Is it worth six weeks of your time to make sure they end up in the right place?

CONCLUSION:

I would like to conclude this message today by asking a series of questions that I want you to answer internally:

- Will we accept this challenge or just discard it as if it is unimportant?
- What could be more important than doing something to make sure those in our circle of influence end up in the right place eternally?
- Shouldn't we be willing to overcome our timidity as it relates to eternal souls?
- Shouldn't we be willing to inconvenience our schedules to make a difference in the lives of those who are on the wrong road?

Let me reiterate my challenge one more time: Make a hit list of families we know who are un-churched and invite one of those families to church and a life group each week for six consecutive weeks.